

Instructor Guide

Lesson Metadata

Field	Detail
Path	Digital Independence Path
Course	Course 18: Professional Presence & Opportunity Building
Lesson	Lesson 4: Share What You Know
Age Range	15–18
Format	Live, instructor-led
Duration	60 minutes
Tools	LinkedIn (16+) OR portfolio "Notes"/Blog section (Course 16 site) OR Google Docs; Canva; a content-planning doc/sheet
Prerequisite	Course 16 personal site or portfolio exists; Course 18 Lessons 1–3 completed (professional presence basics, profile/bio, goal-setting for opportunities)
Deliverable link	This lesson produces Content Piece #1 of 5 required for the course's "5 pieces of professional content" milestone

Overview

Students write and prepare to publish the first of five short pieces of original content: a tip, a lesson learned from a project, or a mini-tutorial. The lesson centers on one repeatable formula so students never face a blank page, and on one core value: **teach something small and specific, honestly, rather than trying to sound like an expert on everything**. By the end, every student has a complete draft ready for final formatting and posting (LinkedIn post, portfolio Notes/Blog entry, or shared Google Doc, depending on their track).

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to: 1. Explain why narrow, honest, specific content performs better and feels more authentic than broad, impressive-sounding claims. 2. Apply a three-part content formula (What I was doing → What I learned/noticed → Why it might help someone else) to a real experience of their own. 3. Draft a complete, honest, non-exaggerated content piece (100–250 words) ready for platform-specific formatting. 4. Identify red flags of exaggeration or vagueness in their own writing and revise them out.

Prep Checklist (Before Class)

- [] Confirm each student's publishing track: LinkedIn post vs. portfolio Notes/Blog vs. Google Doc.
- [] Have the fictional "worked example" (Jordan R., see Student Lesson) ready to project or share.
- [] Open a blank doc/slide for the live demo — do not pre-write the demo draft; you will build it live in front of students.
- [] Have each student bring one recent project, class exercise, or personal coding attempt to draw content from (remind them a day ahead if possible).
- [] Have the Worksheet ready to share (digital or printable).
- [] Test screen-share/demo tool for Canva and Google Docs.

Materials

- Student_Lesson.md (student-facing)
 - Worksheet.md (Content Piece #1 Draft + tracker)
 - A shared or projected copy of the Jordan R. example
 - Access to Canva, Google Docs, LinkedIn, or portfolio Notes/Blog section per student track
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Teaching Sequence

1. Hook & Frame (5 min)

Open with a direct question: *"Has anyone ever explained something to a friend — a game trick, a recipe, a homework shortcut — and they said 'oh that's actually really helpful'?"* Take 2–3 answers. Point out: that is exactly what professional content is. Not a TED talk. Not a resume. One small useful thing, explained clearly.

State the lesson's core rule out loud and keep it visible the whole class:

Teach something small and specific. Don't try to sound like an expert on everything.

2. Why This Matters (5 min)

Talking points: - People (including future teachers, mentors, internship reviewers, or college admissions readers) trust specific stories over broad claims. "I debugged a loop that kept off-by-one errors and learned to test edge cases first" is more convincing than "I am skilled in Python and problem-solving." - Specific content is also *easier to write* — you already have the details, you just have to report them. - This piece is #1 of 5 for the course milestone. Getting a repeatable formula now saves time on pieces 2–5.

3. Introduce the Content Formula (5 min)

Write/display the three-part formula:

1. **What I was doing** — the task, project, or situation (1–2 sentences).
2. **What I learned or noticed** — the specific tip, insight, or mistake-turned-lesson (2–3 sentences).
3. **Why it might help someone else** — one sentence connecting it outward to a reader.

Emphasize: this is a formula, not a rulebook. Order can flex slightly, but all three parts should be present.

4. Live Demo: Drafting a Fictional Student's First Content Piece (15 min)

Do this live, out loud, showing your thinking — do not just present a finished piece.

- Invent (or use) a fictional student, e.g., "Marcus," who just finished a small project: a simple weather-lookup app in Course 15/16 that kept crashing when the user typed a city name with a space in it.
- Narrate your drafting process step by step:
- "What was Marcus doing? Let's write that first, plainly." → *"I was building a small weather app that looks up a city and shows the forecast."*
- "What did he learn?" Push for specificity: not "I learned about errors" but *"I learned that user input needs to be cleaned before it's used — I didn't expect someone to type 'New York' with a space and it broke my lookup until I added a simple `.strip()` and reformatted the string."*
- "Why would this help someone else?" → *"If you're building anything that takes user text input, test it with spaces, weird capitalization, and typos before you assume it works."*
- Assemble the three parts into a short paragraph (100–150 words) live, reading it back and trimming filler.
- Add a **hook** (opening line) and a **takeaway** (closing line) — see Key Terms in Student Lesson — and show how they bookend the piece.
- Deliberately show one bad first draft that oversells ("I mastered debugging and became an expert in error handling") and revise it down to something honest and specific, so students see the correction happen, not just the end result.

5. Discussion Questions (5 min)

Ask and take answers from several students: - "What's a small, specific thing you learned this month that you could explain in three sentences?" - "What's the difference between 'I'm skilled in coding' and a specific story? Which would you trust more from a stranger?" - "Why might a short, honest post actually be *more* impressive than a long, impressive-sounding one?"

6. Address Common Misconceptions (5 min)

Name these directly and correct them:

- **"I have nothing worth sharing."** Response: Everyone who has done any exercise, project, or even a tricky homework problem has something. The bar is not "invent something impressive" — it's "report one true, specific thing." Remind them of the demo: Marcus's content came from one bug.
- **"It needs to sound impressive or formal."** Response: Formal, stiff language usually makes content *less* trustworthy and harder to read. Plain, honest, conversational language explaining one real thing beats jargon every time. No inflated titles ("I engineered a robust solution") for small tasks.

- **"I need to wait until I've done something bigger."** Response: This is content piece 1 of 5 — the goal is to build the habit now with what they have today, not to wait for a impressive future project that may never feel "big enough."

7. Independent Work Time: Draft Content Piece #1 (15 min)

Students work through the Worksheet's fill-in template individually. Instructor circulates. See "Common Student Difficulties" and "Troubleshooting" below for what to watch for.

8. Self-Check & Peer Share (Optional, 3 min if time allows)

Students run their own draft through the Worksheet's "does this sound honest and specific?" self-check. If time allows, pair students to read one line of their draft aloud to each other.

9. Lesson Close (2 min)

- Recap the formula and the core rule once more.
- Remind students: this draft is not yet the final formatted post — formatting/publishing (Canva graphics if used, platform-specific posting) is covered in the next step of the course.
- Preview: "Next, you'll do this four more times — but now you have the formula, so it gets faster."
- Confirm submission instructions (see Student Lesson) and due date/time.

Common Student Difficulties & Troubleshooting

Difficulty	What it looks like	Instructor response
Blank page / "nothing to write about"	Student stares at worksheet, says they haven't done anything worth mentioning	Ask 3 quick questions: "What's something you built or fixed in the last 2 weeks in this course? What went wrong the first time? What did you change?" Almost always surfaces material.
Over-claiming / inflated language	Draft says "I'm now an expert in..." or "I mastered..." for a small task	Point to the core rule on the board. Ask: "Would you be comfortable if your instructor asked you three follow-up questions about this claim?" If not, scale the claim down to match the actual experience.
Too vague	"I learned a lot about coding" with no specifics	Ask: "What's the ONE specific line, error, or moment? Name it." Push for a concrete detail (a function name, an error message, a specific fix).
Sounds like a resume bullet, not a story	"Proficient in debugging methodologies"	Ask them to say it out loud to a friend first, then write down what they just said. Spoken language is usually more honest and readable than written "professional" language.
Missing the "why it helps others" line	Draft stops after describing what happened, with no outward connection	Prompt: "If a younger student read this, what would you want them to do differently because of it?"

Difficulty	What it looks like	Instructor response
Anxious about publishing publicly	Worried about being judged, especially on LinkedIn	Remind them: content piece is reviewed before anything is posted publicly (see below), and portfolio-first/Google Doc options exist if they're not comfortable with LinkedIn yet.
Confusing platforms	Unsure whether to write for LinkedIn tone vs. blog tone	Clarify: for this lesson, focus on the content itself (the three-part formula). Platform-specific formatting is a later step; today's draft works for any of the three tracks.

How to Review Student Drafts

When circulating or reviewing submitted drafts, check for: 1. **All three formula parts present** — task, learning, outward value. 2. **Specificity** — is there at least one concrete detail (a real tool, error, number, or decision)? Vague drafts get sent back with the "name the specific detail" prompt. 3. **Honesty check** — no claims of expertise/mastery disproportionate to the described experience. Flag words like "expert," "mastered," "guru" attached to small tasks. 4. **Length** — roughly 100–250 words. Too short usually means missing a formula part; too long usually means unnecessary padding or resume-style language creeping in. 5. **Hook and takeaway present** — opening line draws a reader in, closing line lands the point. 6. **Track-appropriate readiness** — LinkedIn-track drafts should read as a complete post; portfolio/Google Doc drafts should read as a complete short blog entry or note.

Do **not** require polish or perfect formatting at this stage — that is out of scope for this lesson. The bar is: complete, honest, specific, three-part draft.

Lesson Close Script (Suggested)

"Today you wrote the first of five pieces of content — and you did it without needing a huge accomplishment to talk about. You used something real, kept it honest, and made it specific enough that someone else could actually use it. That's the whole skill. Next time, you'll do this again, faster, because you already know the formula."